

1979

INDIA

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

<< **REWIND**

OVER AND OUT:
Morarji Desai

SHAKY GROUND

After a brief two-year stint, the first non-Congress government to rule at the Centre, the Janata Party regime led by Morarji Desai collapsed due to various internal contradictions. Deputy Prime Minister Charan Singh raised the issue of dual membership of some of the senior ministers who were also members of the Jan Sangh, the precursor to B.J.P. Desai, alienated from the Cabinet, the party, the administration and the people, chose to remain unperturbed and indifferent. Result: Singh pulled out of the government forcing Desai to quit office. President N. Sanjeeva Reddy had to invite Singh to form the government since the opposition Congress party decided to extend its support to his Bharatiya Lok Dal. The Jat euphoria was, however, shortlived as Singh quit five months later carrying with him the dubious record of being the only head of government to leave office without ever facing Parliament.

STOOPING TO CONQUER

The Janata Party, in a first, threatened to call for the impeachment of President Sanjeeva Reddy when after the fall of the Desai Government, he called upon Charan Singh, who had a letter of support from the Congress, rather than the Janata Party leader Jagjivan Ram, to form the new government in July.

FIRST CUT

India's first remote sensing low orbit earth observation satellite, Bhaskaran 1, carrying TV and microwave cameras, was launched by the Russian launch vehicle Intercosmos.

<< DID YOU KNOW

Ten days before the Naga massacre in the Doyang Valley in Assam, a boy had run in from across the Indo-Nepal border, warning all, including the police, about the coming attack. No one paid heed and on January 5, Naga warriors went on a 12-hour rampage that left over 1,000 dead.

